American Modernists Contemplating Asia

Reviewing the Journey of Mark Tobey and Isamu Noguchi

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This article is dedicated to my mentor, Professor Richard R. Brettell, for his wisdom and passion that have enlightened so many, and that will be carried on by those who have been deeply touched.

The Third Mind and a Janus-faced America

In 2009, The Solomon R. Guggenheim Museum in New York held an exhibition: *The Third Mind: American Artists Contemplating Asia 1860-1989.* The curator Alexandra Munroe introduces the show by saying:

> *While Europe has long been recognized as the font of mainstream American art movements, the exhibition explores an alternative lineage of creative culture that is aligned with America's Pacific vista—Asia. Vanguard artists consistently looked toward "the East" to forge an independent artistic identity that would define the modern age—and the modern mind—through a new understanding of existence, nature, and consciousness.*[2]

An exhibition review by Andrew Solomon states that conventional wisdom by then still held that contemporary art in the East was either derivative or unsophisticated.[3] Solomon recalls that Munroe's 1994 exhibition, *Scream against the Sky: Japanese Art After 1945* was "one of the first major museum shows in New York to correct that perception." While being interviewed for *The Third Mind by the Los Angeles Times,* Alexandra Munroe also emphasizes the importance of the West Coast, long overlooked in the narrative of American art history for the same reason: "Traditionally, modern and contemporary and avant-garde art have always been discussed in their relationship to Europe. The natural bias has been New York and East Coast."[4]

Obviously, Munroe has been seeking for an alternative lineage and geography of American art history. But by no means is she the first pioneer. In fact, over fifty years before, Mark Tobey, who is also included in

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2 Munroe, A. *The Third Mind: American Artists Contemplate Asia, 1860-1989*. Guggenheim Museum, New York, January 30 to April 19, 2009.

3 Andrew Solomon, "The Third Mind," andrewsolomon.com/articles/the-third-mind-2/ (accessed January 30, 2020)

4 Scarlet Cheng, 'The Third Mind: American Artists Contemplate Asia: 1860-1989' at the Guggenheim," *Los Angeles Times*, Feb. 1, 2009, www.latimes.com/entertainment/la-ca-asia1-2009feb01-story.html (accessed January 30, 2020).

The Third Mind, had already promoted America's Pacific vista by stating his view of a "Janus-faced" America in the 1946 MoMA exhibition *Fourteen Americans*:

> *Ours is a universal time and the significances of such a time all point to the need for the universalizing of the consciousness and the conscience of man. It is in the awareness of this that our future depends unless we are to sink into a universal dark age. … America more than any other country is placed geographically to lead in this understanding, and if from past methods of behavior she has constantly looked toward Europe, today she must assume her position, Janus-faced, toward Asia, for in not too long a time the waves of the Orient shall wash heavily upon her shores.*[5]

Fourteen Americans was one of a series of exhibitions with which MoMA aimed to promote the awareness and studies of modern art in the United States. The fact that "youth happens to be in the majority" of the selected artists in both the 1946 and 1942 shows (*Americans, 1942: 18 Artists from 9 States*) echoed the emergence of American art as a major player in the battles over the discourse power of modernism. Such an ambition of de-marginalizing and internationalizing American art is best illustrated by the curator Dorothy C. Miller's (1904-2003) introduction of *Fourteen Americans*: "The idiom is American but there is no hint of regionalism or chauvinistic tendency. On the contrary, there is a profound consciousness that the world of art is one world and that it contains the Orient no less than Europe and the Americas."[6] This obviously resonates with Tobey's positioning of America as "Janus-faced."



Figure 1 Portrait of Teng Baiye with dedication to Mark Tobey, 1926. University of Washington Libraries, Special Collections, UW 23723z.

Mark Tobey's white writing—knitting the "chaos-catcher"

Mark Tobey (1890-1976) was born in Centerville, Wisconsin and educated at the School of the Art Institute of Chicago (1906-1908), but he established his career in the West Coast by founding the art department at The Cornish School in Seattle, Washington in 1921. He is also known nationally as the founder of the Northwest School which includes Guy Anderson (1906-1998), Kenneth Callahan (1905-1986), and Morris Graves (1910-2001). While teaching at the Cornish, Tobey became

5 Miller, Dorothy C. ed. with statements by the artists and others. 1946. *Fourteen Americans*. The Museum of Modern Art. The full text of the catalogue is accessible at www.moma.org/calendar/exhibitions/3196

6 *Fourteen Americans.* exh. cat.

friends with Teng Baiye (滕圭，字白也 1900-1980), a Chinese student who was studying at the University of Washington (Figure 1).[7] Tobey had long been interested in mysticism. Before converting to the Bahá'í faith in 1918, he had been attracted to Eastern philosophy and spiritualism. After meeting Teng, Tobey soon started learning calligraphy under Teng's guidance. From 1929 to 1933, Teng Baiye carried on research studies at Harvard University. His dissertation focused on a survey and evaluation of looted Chinese cultural relics, for which he traveled extensively in Europe on an exchange fellowship of the Harvard-Yenching Institute. In 1925, Tobey also traveled in Europe, including a pilgrimage to the Bahá'í holy site in Haifa, and a visit to Acre to learn more about Persian and Arabian calligraphy. From 1930 to 1937 he taught art and philosophy at the Dartington Hall School in Devonshire, England. After Teng returned to China, Tobey visited him in Shanghai in 1934. During that trip, he also went to Japan, and even spent a period of time at a Zen monastery where he studied Zen painting and haiku poetry, as well as calligraphy and its philosophical underpinnings.

Calligraphy is the meta-language of traditional Chinese painting. For literati painting especially, calligraphy is the essential tool that requires day-to-day practice and takes one's lifetime to perfect. Examining the friends' biographies up to the early 1930s, Tobey could only have studied with Teng for five years at the most. It is doubtful whether Teng ever chose the copybook to teach Tobey, even though that is the only legitimate way for any beginner of calligraphy in China. What really matters is not a good grasp of the model calligraphy but Tobey's ready embrace of cross-cultural differences: Asian art forms, compositions, skills as well as aesthetic and philosophical ideas (Figure 2). For him, Teng Baiye was a catalyst, and his own extensive travels were the fertilizer.

In 1937, Tobey left England and returned to the United States because of the increasing threat of war in Europe. He lived in Seattle until 1960. During those two decades, the influence of calligraphy first appeared in his semi-abstract cityscapes of the 1930s, and gradually gave rise to his unique technique of "white writing" with which his work became more and more abstract (Figure 3). White writing is a way of superimposing a web of white (or light-colored) calligraphic marks and symbols atop densely interwoven brushstrokes (usually in grey or dark colors). In 1944, the Willard Gallery in New York showed Tobey's white writing paintings for the first time, which officially announced his artistic breakthrough. In 1951, the Whitney Museum of American Art held a solo exhibition for Tobey, which traveled throughout the country. And in 1958, Tobey represented United States and won the first prize for painting at the 29th Venice Biennale. Following this international success, his works were shown in the documenta exhibition in Kassel (1959, 1964) and many other exhibitions around the world. In 1960 Tobey moved to Basel, Switzerland, where he died on April 24, 1976.

Mark Tobey invented the all-over composition and linear network that anticipated Jackson Pollock (1912-1956). But unlike Clement Greenberg (1909-1994) who discounted cross-cultural fertilization, Tobey always acknowledged the Eastern sources of his art. He was confident in what

7 No documentation shows when they met exactly. A photo of Teng Baiye given to Tobey as a gift is dated December 16, 1926. For more information, see the exhibition *Mark Tobey and Teng Baiye: Seattle/Shanghai* at the Frye Art Museum, and the book edited by Danzker, Jo-Anne Birnie and Scott Lawrimore. eds. 2014. *Mark Tobey / Teng Baiye: Seattle / Shanghai*. University of Washington Press.